THE 2004

FREEZY AWARDS

The best, biggest, and most James Bond-Like of the year!

THE FRANK SINATRA "MY WAY" AWARD

Tanner Hall employs a terrain-park standard to get comfortable in the big mountains.

When Tanner Hall went to Norway last March, he was filling Pep Fujas' spot from the previous winter's expedition that included Seth Morrison, Eric Pollard, and CR Johnson. That trip—well-documented in MSP's *Focused*—produced one of the more impressive meetings of skiing minds in recent memory as Morrison showed the younguns how to navigate big mountains and the younguns showed Morrison some new tricks to throw in those mountains.

"I was actually more intimidated by the group I was with than the skiing itself," says Hall. And he had plenty of time to think about it. This year, the anxious crew spent two full weeks watching storms batter the range they intended to ski, and they eventually bailed to a whole new zone before the weather finally broke. Intimidated or not, time is money on a film shoot, and no one buys movies to see warm-up runs.

In that situation, skiing within the upper edge of your comfort zone is the best option. Since Tanner's comfort zone looks more like the Park City terrain park than a helicopter-accessed peak, he did what any good park rat would do on his first few runs of the day: he threw 180s.

Never mind that he threw 180s in the middle of the kind of chutes that, just a season ago, he had a hard time skiing down. Never mind that riding fakie in a true backcountry environment is still beyond the grasp of even the best pros. Never mind the fact that he was skiing backward down a frigging mountain. Tanner was just happy to shake the cobwebs off. "I had a couple of good 180s that day," he recalls. "It was good for the confidence."

Tanner is the first to admit that he has a lot to learn in big-mountain environments, but now that he's developed a way to get comfortable quickly, class is definitely in session. "Tanner wanted to prove to himself that he can step things up right away in any conditions," says Johnson, who had a first-row seat for the antics. "And when the kid wants to prove something to himself, there's just no stopping him."—**Jeff Foss**

Skier: Mike Wilson
Location: Vail, Colorado
Photo: Nate Abbott

XBOX AWARD

Mike Wilson brings video-game-style aerials to the big-air arena.

When Mike Wilson arrived for the 2004 Big Air at the U.S. Freeskiing Open, few expected anything impressive—the eighteen-year-old Vermonter was sick with a stomach virus and puking his guts out. It was impressive enough that he was able to keep his (very little) dinner down while standing in the sub-zero temperatures of the start, under the lights at Vail. Then, on his second jump and without a word to anyone, he contorted his diminutive frame into one of the wildest double inverts ever seen in a big-air comp.

The crowd went crazy with applause and mass confusion. No one could agree upon what they had just seen:

"Holy crap! Was that an underflip to misty flip?" asked one fan.

"I think it was a rodeo 5 to Lincoln loop 180!"

"Are you kidding? That was a triple axle to quadruple lutz!"

After several slow-motion replays, Wilson's trick was more or less deciphered in the judges' booth. He essentially threw a double underflip—something never seen before in competition and a trick Wilson himself had only recently figured out.

"I learned it playing *Amp II* on Xbox," says Wilson, who had never even attempted the trick before that night. "In the video game, you can do these crazy off-axis doubles without jerking around too much between rotations. My friends bet me I couldn't do it."

Needless to say, Wilson won the bet. By the time he made his way to the top for his third jump, the trick had already been dubbed a "Wilson Flip." But it wasn't meant to be. Jumping against Peter Olenick in the best-of-three format, Wilson overshot the landing on his second Wilson Flip attempt, and Olenick moved on with a textbook fakie 1080. Still, Wilson's not about to put down his Xbox controller.

"It seems like every rotation has been done with a single flip," he says. "At some point, I think, we'll have to go to doubles."—**JF**

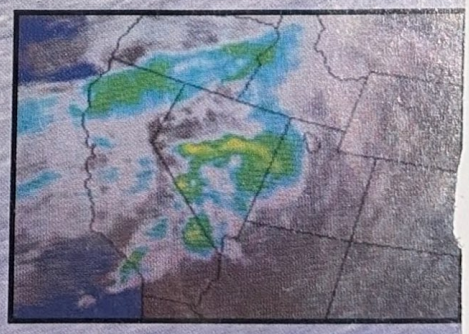
Skier: Jordan Schweizer
Location: Alta backcountry, Utah
Photo: Adam Clark

EL DUMPO

Utah gets hit by the mother of all snowstorms.

What did you get for Christmas last year? Argyle socks? A George Foreman Grill? Whatever it was, if you weren't in Utah when you got it, you didn't get squat.

Last December, residents near Utah's Wasatch Range received the so-called "Twelve Days Of Christmas Storm." The first of the palm-sized flakes touched down on Christmas Eve, and places like Alta and Snowbird were soon reporting numbers that even Enron bean counters couldn't have cooked up: 63 inches in 60 hours. That's over five feet in just two and a half days!

Little Cottonwood Canyon was closed all day on December 26 due to avalanche danger but reopened the next day with enough powder to stun even the most hardcore local. "It was the biggest storm I've seen since the early 80s, when it used to dump like crazy," says Gus Gilman, who's been at Alta since 1978 and now works as ski patrol director. But the madness was far from over. It dumped another 21 inches on December 29 and 30, and then another 31 inches during the first three days of January!

The Twelve Days Of Christmas Storm created panic in Salt Lake City, where there was a run on shovels and ice salt in stores throughout the region. Snowplows were in such short supply that officials called on anyone with a valid driver's license and access to a plow for aid. The storm got so bad that power was knocked out in nearly 70,000 homes and businesses across the state, including the abode of Park City resident Brant Moles: "It's a small price to pay for such good skiing. I lost count of how many chest-deep days I had."—**JF**